The Unsent Letter

Silvia, I found this in the cedar chest of the Sanctuary, under the oldest charts. An Oracle of long ago wrote it, centuries before me, to the Mirror Speaker of Tower III, and never sent it. She wrote it the way the glass sees, as the people of the mirror do. Hold the page up to a mirror and read it.

A.

To the Mirror Speaker of the third tower,

Forgive me. I closed my door to you when your crossed the plateau to see me, and I have been sorry every night since.

Now hear what only we two know. Your mirror did not fall. We broke it together, into nine pieces, and we hid each piece in a different room of your theatre. While the nine are apart, no one can turn the Astrolabe alone: not the Order, not you, not I.

And beware the Ashes. They were old before the Order was born. They keep a fire older than our first star, and they want what the Astrolabe opens. They will come to your smiling.

The first piece sleeps behind a thousand faces. Only the one who sees what is not equal will find it.

The Oracle of the Sandstone Sanctuary

In the mirror the words turn round, and so do the people who wrote them. Tower III is the house of the mirror: there, everything may be the other way round.

A.

Leonardo wrote his notebooks the same way, from right to left. I always thought he did it to hide his secrets. Perhaps he only wanted to be read by someone patient.

H.